Executive view: Sales Navigator vs 17 competitors

Seen 2026-10-18. Scores are analyst judgment on a 1–5 rubric across 11 sales stages (full matrix). Evidence chips open the screenshot, clip or video at the timestamp.

Headline

1. Sales Navigator holds a clear lead on 2 of 11 stages (Lead discovery & search and Warm path & relationships, 5/5); on warm path, 0 of 17 rivals match or beat it. grid 📄 Vendor page · 2026-10-18
2. It trails on execution and access: outreach 1/5 (InMail capped), pipeline 1/5 (not offered), API/MCP 1/5 while 16 of 17 rivals ship an official MCP. API page 📄 Vendor page · 2026-10-18
3. On buying signals, 3 rivals score above it (ZoomInfo, Common Room, UserGems: 5 vs 4); evidence is mostly vendor pages, only 3 of 198 cells hands-on. confidence 📄 Vendor page · 2026-10-18

The three differentiators: where each rival stands

Mapping rule: for each differentiator, average the rival's matrix scores on the listed stages (scored stages only) and compare with Sales Navigator's average. **Beats** = rival ≥ 0.5 higher · **matches** = within 0.5 · **trails** = ≥ 0.5 lower · **no data** = no scored stage. Red = threat, green = Sales Navigator ahead.

Best leads · Most up-to-date, trusted professional network

Stages: Lead discovery & search, Contact data accuracy & enrichment · Sales Navigator 4/5 · beats 1, matches 5, trails 9, no data 2

Apollo.io TRAILS	ZoomInfo MATCHES	Cognism MATCHES	Clay BEATS	Rox TRAILS	Actively NO DATA
Monaco MATCHES	Salesforce TRAILS	HubSpot TRAILS	Common Room MATCHES	UserGems TRAILS	Unify TRAILS
Outreach TRAILS	Salesloft NO DATA	Gong TRAILS	Lusha MATCHES	Seamless.AI TRAILS	

Best path in · Relationships and connections

Stages: Warm path & relationships · Sales Navigator 5/5 · beats 0, matches 0, trails 10, no data 7

Apollo.io TRAILS	ZoomInfo TRAILS	Cognism TRAILS	Clay TRAILS	Rox NO DATA	Actively NO DATA
Monaco NO DATA	Salesforce NO DATA	HubSpot NO DATA	Common Room TRAILS	UserGems TRAILS	Unify TRAILS
Outreach TRAILS	Salesloft NO DATA	Gong NO DATA	Lusha TRAILS	Seamless.AI TRAILS	

First-party buying signals · Profile views, content engagement

Stages: Buying signals & timing · Sales Navigator 4/5 · beats 3, matches 4, trails 10, no data 0

Apollo.io TRAILS	ZoomInfo BEATS	Cognism TRAILS	Clay MATCHES	Rox TRAILS	Actively MATCHES
Monaco MATCHES	Salesforce TRAILS	HubSpot TRAILS	Common Room BEATS	UserGems BEATS	Unify MATCHES
Outreach TRAILS	Salesloft TRAILS	Gong TRAILS	Lusha TRAILS	Seamless.AI TRAILS	

Biggest threats

1. Agents cannot reach Sales Navigator; rivals invite them in

16 of 17 rivals ship an official MCP; LinkedIn's partner program is closed to new applicants and its User Agreement bans bots. Lusha and Apollo open API access on Free plans. 📄 Vendor page · LinkedIn SNAP · 2026-10-18

2. Signal specialists outscore it on timing

ZoomInfo, Common Room and UserGems score 5/5 on buying signals vs Sales Navigator 4/5; UserGems and Clay market job-change and champion tracking. 📄 Vendor page · UserGems · 2026-10-18

3. Rival extensions sit on top of Sales Navigator search

ZoomInfo, Cognism and Lusha demo extensions on Sales Navigator pages; Evaboot cites no native lead export as the reason (user videos, 2024, dated). ▶ User video · 2024-07-30 dated

4. Bundled agentic outreach at volume

Apollo and Outreach score 5/5 on outreach vs Sales Navigator 1/5; a Salesforce partner states Agentforce SDR sends up to 1,800 emails/day out of the box (Aug 2026). ▶ User video · Salesforce partner · 2026-08-21

Five moves that matter

1. **Ship a sanctioned Sales Navigator MCP/API on seat entitlements.** Closes the 1/5 API score; 16 of 17 rivals already have one, and unofficial servers (LinkMCP, Unipile) drive signed-in accounts against the User Agreement. 📄 Vendor page · LinkedIn User Agreement
2. **Make the warm path the agent-facing product.** No rival beats Sales Navigator on warm path (10 trail, 7 no data); expose relationship maps and TeamLink paths as queryable tools. 📄 Vendor page · relationship maps
3. **Package first-party signals against third-party intent.** Profile views and content engagement are unique to LinkedIn; three rivals score 5/5 on signals with third-party or CRM data, and two agencies report ignoring Apollo's intent filters (Nov 2025).
   ▶ User video · agency · 2025-11-24
4. **Remove the reason for scraping extensions.** A native, ToS-compliant export or CRM push removes the gap rivals' extensions fill; Advanced Plus CRM sync is daily (CRM 3/5). 💬 Third-party page · CRM sync
5. **Price agentic actions inside the seat, not as credits.** HubSpot's Prospecting Agent now consumes credits after a free period (May 2026); Unify draws all seats from one credit pool. A seat-included agent tier is a contrast point; this is our inference.
   ▶ User video · HubSpot partner · 2026-05-05

How confident are we

Hands-on coverage
Inside the app: Unify only (trial, 2026-10-18). Signup blocked: Apollo (rejected email), Clay (account locked), Lusha (phone required). 3 of 198 matrix cells hands-on. 🧪 Apollo block 🧪 Clay block 🧪 Lusha block

Evidence by type (159 attached items)
Vendor page 119 (75%) · User video 21 (13%) · Hands-on 15 (9%) · Third-party page 3 (2%) · Help docs 1 (1%)

Matrix cells by primary evidence: vendor docs/demo video 145 · gap 34 · not offered 13 · third-party review 3 · hands-on 3

Known gaps
34 of 198 cells have no evidence. Sales Navigator has captures for 6 of 11 stages. Rox and Common Room have no independent user videos; Actively and Unify videos are by rivals. 19 of 44 user videos are flagged as sponsored or conflicted (rival, partner or affiliate); 27 are over 12 months old and down-weighted. Outreach and personalization in Unify not tested (mailbox connection required).